

Phase 1 — Ideation

Budget Tracker · Accelerator Hackathon

Step 1 — Product and User Basics

1.1 Product one-liner

Product name (working): Clarifin

One-liner: For financially anxious adults who live on their phone, I am building an AI-powered budget tracker that speaks to them like a mentor so they can finally understand where their money goes and take one clear action to improve it.

1.2 Who is this for

Primary user role: Independently living adult (22-40) who earns a regular income but has no active system for tracking spending — globally distributed, English-speaking.

Where they use this (context): On their phone or laptop, briefly, in the moments right after spending — on the commute, at their desk between tasks, or at home in the evening reviewing the day. The session is short: log something, check the snapshot, get the insight, close it.

Top 3 pains today:

1. They have no idea how much they've spent this week until they check their bank app — by which point it's too late to change anything.
 2. Their bank app shows transactions but gives zero interpretation — no categories, no patterns, no "here's what to do about it."
 3. Categorising expenses manually (in a spreadsheet or budgeting app) feels like admin work, so they quit after a few days.
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1.3 MVP success for this hackathon

By the end of 3 days, a user should be able to: Type an expense in plain English, have it automatically categorised by AI, see a real-time dashboard of their week's spending by category, and receive a plain-English mentor summary that names one specific thing they can do differently.

Simple success metric for the demo (one line): A judge types one expense, sees it categorised instantly, and reads an AI insight that feels like genuine financial advice — all within 30 seconds of landing on the app.

Step 2 — Deepen the Problem with 5 Whys

2.1 Problem statement v0

People know they're overspending but don't know where or what to do about it, because the tools available either require too much effort to maintain or give data without any actionable meaning.

2.2 Five Whys table

Why #	Question	Answer
1	Why is this a problem for your user?	They feel financial anxiety without clarity — they suspect they're wasting money but can't pinpoint it, which creates stress and avoidance rather than action.
2	Why does that happen right now?	Because expense tracking requires consistent manual effort (opening an app, finding the right category, entering a form) that breaks down within days. The friction of logging is higher than the perceived immediate benefit.
3	Why haven't existing tools solved this well?	Bank apps are passive — they show you what happened, not what it means. Budgeting apps like YNAB and Copilot are powerful but complex and assume the user already has financial discipline. The AI tools that exist (e.g. Cleo) skew young and gimmicky, not trustworthy.
4	Why is your user still stuck?	Because no tool combines truly effortless entry (natural language, no forms) with genuinely personalised, plain-English insight that feels like advice rather than a report. The gap between data and meaning has never been properly closed.
5	Why does solving this now matter for them?	Financial habits compound. A user who gets one clear, actionable insight per week — delivered in a voice they trust — will make marginally better decisions that add up to significant change over months. The cost of continuing to avoid it is real money lost.

2.3 Final problem statement

Financially anxious adults have the data — their bank shows every transaction — but not the meaning. No tool translates spending patterns into a clear, trustworthy, human-toned signal that tells them what to actually do next. The result is avoidance: they don't track, don't improve, and stay anxious. Clarifin closes the gap between data and decision with AI that speaks like a mentor, not a machine.

This is the line used in all prompts, the PRD, and the demo.

Step 3 — Competitor Scan and AI Feature Analysis

3.1 Competitor reference table

Product / Tool	Links / Pages checked	What they do well	What frustrates users
YNAB (You Need a Budget)	ynab.com — features, pricing, dashboard UI	(1) Deep category budgeting with envelope methodology. (2) Strong community and educational content that builds financial literacy.	(1) Steep learning curve — new users report feeling overwhelmed in week one. (2) Manual entry still required; bank sync is unreliable for non-US banks.
Cleo	meetcleo.com — home, roast mode, features	(1) Conversational AI that makes money feel approachable and fun. (2) Automated spend analysis with personality — users actually engage with it.	(1) Tone is too gimmicky/Gen-Z for users who want to feel genuinely in control. (2) Core financial insight is shallow — entertainment over substance.
Emma	emma-app.com — features, dashboard	(1) Clean, modern UI with strong subscription tracking. (2) Good multi-bank aggregation for UK/EU users.	(1) Requires Open Banking connection — many users don't trust it or can't access it. (2) AI features feel bolted on, not central to the experience.

3.2 AI feature extraction

Prompt used:

"I am building a product similar to YNAB, Cleo, and Emma — an AI-powered personal budget tracker where users log expenses in natural language and receive AI-generated mentor-style insights. Here are notes from their feature and pricing pages. Extract all unique features into a table with columns: Feature | What it does | Why users care | Which tool(s) have it. Highlight patterns and must-have features."

Extracted feature table:

Feature	What it does	Why users care	Tool(s)	Differentiator?
Expense logging	Manual entry of transactions	Core utility — without this, nothing works	All	—
Auto-categorisation	AI or rule-based category assignment	Removes the biggest friction point in tracking	YNAB, Emma, Cleo	—
Spending dashboard	Visual summary of spend by category and time	At-a-glance awareness replaces anxiety	All	—
Bank sync / Open Banking	Pulls transactions automatically from bank	Eliminates manual entry entirely	Emma, YNAB (US)	—
Budget envelopes / limits	User sets category spending caps	Creates guardrails before overspending happens	YNAB	—
Subscription tracking	Flags recurring charges	Surfaces forgotten subscriptions — direct money saving	Emma, Cleo	—
AI chat interface	User asks questions about their spending	Makes data interactive and personal	Cleo	—
Weekly/monthly summary	Periodic report of overall financial health	Gives users a ritual moment to reflect	YNAB, Emma	—
Natural language entry ★	User types expenses as they'd say them out loud	Dramatically lowers logging friction vs. forms	None (gap)	★
Mentor-tone AI insight ★	AI delivers personalised, empowering advice	Turns data into a decision — the missing link	None (gap)	★
Essential vs. avoidable flag ★	AI tags each expense as necessary or discretionary	Helps users see what's controllable without judgement	None (gap)	★
Multi-currency support ★	User selects home currency; app formats all	Makes the app genuinely global from	Partial (Emma)	★

Feature	What it does	Why users care	Tool(s)	Differentiator?
	amounts correctly	day one	EU)	
Goal tracking	User sets a savings goal and tracks progress	Creates forward-looking motivation	YNAB, Cleo	—
Gamification / streaks	Rewards consistent logging behaviour	Habit formation — keeps users coming back	Cleo	—
Export to CSV	Download transaction history	Power users need this for tax, accountants	YNAB, Emma	—

Patterns identified:

- Every serious competitor requires either bank sync (high trust barrier) or tedious manual forms (high effort barrier). Neither has cracked truly frictionless entry.
- AI exists in Cleo but as entertainment, not as a trusted advisor. The mentor tone is an unclaimed position.
- No competitor is built globally-first for currency. Most are UK/US-centric.

File saved: this document (phase1-ideation.md), Section 3.2.

Step 4 — MVP Scope with MoSCoW

4.1 Feature dump

Everything considered for Clarifin:

- Natural language expense entry
- AI auto-categorisation
- Confirmation card (review before saving)
- Spending dashboard (weekly + monthly view)
- Category breakdown chart (donut or bar)
- AI mentor summary ("Your Money Mentor" card)
- Essential vs. avoidable tagging per expense
- Category override by user
- Currency selector (onboarding)
- Multi-currency display with Intl.NumberFormat

- Supabase auth (email login)
- Subscription detection / flagging
- Monthly budget cap per category
- Spending streak / habit tracker
- Goal setting and progress bar
- Export to CSV
- Bank sync / Open Banking
- Multi-language UI
- Push notifications / reminders
- Dark mode

4.2 MoSCoW prioritisation table

Feature	Must	Should	Could	Won't now	Differentiator?	Why placed here
Natural language expense entry	✓				★	The entire product promise depends on frictionless entry — without this it's just another form
AI auto-categorisation	✓				★	Core AI value; without it the entry is just a note
Confirmation card (pre-save)	✓				—	Required for trust — user must be able to catch AI errors before they're stored
Spending dashboard (weekly)	✓				—	Without this there's nothing to demo; it's the payoff for logging
Category breakdown chart	✓				—	Visual proof the categorisation works; essential for demo impact
AI mentor summary card	✓				★	The core differentiator — turns data into meaning. This is the demo's "wow" moment

Feature	Must	Should	Could	Won't now	Differentiator?	Why placed here
Supabase auth (email login)	✓				—	Required for data persistence; without it the app resets on refresh
Currency selector (onboarding)	✓				★	Global positioning is a key differentiator; must work from session one
Multi-currency display formatting	✓				—	Without correct formatting, currency selection is meaningless
Essential vs. avoidable flag		✓			★	Strong differentiator but the app functions without it; adds depth if time allows
Category override by user		✓			—	Expected quality signal for judges; users need to trust they can correct the AI
Monthly budget cap per category			✓		—	Good feature but not needed for demo; dashboard works without it
Subscription detection / flagging			✓		—	Useful insight but requires multiple entries to trigger; not demoable in a hackathon
Spending streak / habit tracker			✓		—	Engagement feature — candy; no time in 3 days
Export to CSV				✓	—	Zero demo value; zero user value in a 3-day build with sample data
Goal setting + progress bar				✓	—	Requires a separate onboarding flow — scope risk
Bank sync / Open Banking				✓	—	Weeks of integration work; completely out of scope

Feature	Must	Should	Could	Won't now	Differentiator?	Why placed here
Multi-language UI				✓	—	English only for v1 — explicitly agreed
Push notifications				✓	—	Requires native app or service worker; no time
Dark mode				✓	—	Nice to have; zero bearing on judging criteria

4.3 Final MVP scope for the hackathon

Single must-have flow committed to ship:

User signs up → selects currency → types an expense in plain English → AI categorises it and tags it essential/avoidable → user confirms → dashboard updates with category chart and AI mentor summary.

Up to 2 should-haves (if time allows, in order of priority):

- 1. Essential vs. avoidable flag displayed per expense in the dashboard list
- 2. Category override — user can tap any expense and reassign its category

Features deliberately parked (with rationale):

Feature	Why parked
Monthly budget caps	Requires additional onboarding step and a separate UI surface — scope risk for day 3
Subscription detection	Needs at least 2-3 sessions of data to trigger meaningfully — not demoable
Spending streaks	Engagement mechanic — zero value for a one-session hackathon demo
Export to CSV	No demo value; judges won't download a file

Phase 1 — End Checklist

Item	Status
✓ Final problem statement is clear	Done — Section 2.3
✓ Primary user and context defined	Done — Section 1.2
✓ Competitor screenshots + feature table done	Done — Section 3.1 and 3.2
✓ Features prioritised with MoSCoW	Done — Section 4.2
✓ One must-have flow + up to 2 should-haves locked	Done — Section 4.3

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